

Education & STEM Innovation

In collaboration with Newton Venture Program, we've researched the educational background of the founders and investors behind the UK's innovative and high-growth STEM companies.

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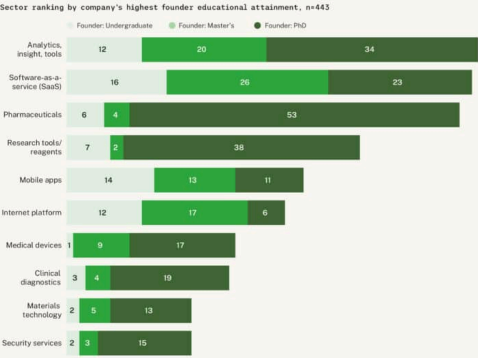
The median value of equity deals by the highest level of founder education
STEM company sector rankings, broken down by founders' highest levels of education

Here's a sneak peek inside

STEM company sectors by founder education

In many of the most populous sectors, there are companies with a range of founder educational backgrounds developing innovative products. Software sectors in particular seem to have a better representation of companies where the highest founder education level is undergraduate. Consider SaaS, mobile apps, and internet platforms where these companies are well represented.

In contrast, sectors that are heavily focused on life sciences, such as pharmaceuticals, research tools/ reagents, and medical devices have proportionally more companies with PhDs as the highest level of founder education. Whilst it seems likely that these sectors do legitimately require a higher degree of knowledge than others, there may also be an aspect of signalling at play given that the nature of life science companies makes them more capital intensive and hence higher risk in the eyes of many investors. As a result, investors may be more likely to back those who – at least on paper – have the most comprehensive qualifications.

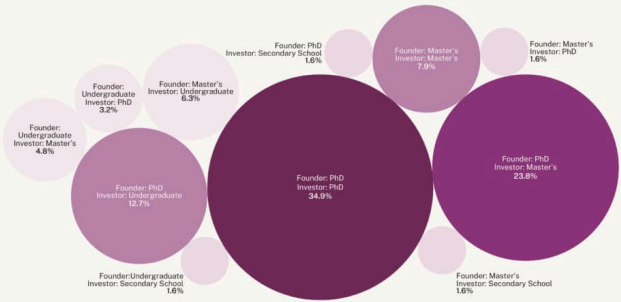


Founder-investor educational pairings

The founder-investor educational pairings show that companies with at least one founder and one investor that have a PhD are the most prevalent in the sample. This may reflect that the underlying cohort of companies is made up of academic spinouts and innovation grant recipients, both types of companies where more PhDs may be more prevalent among founders and investors.

However, the data also suggests that there could be an educational barrier involved in the receipt and allocation of capital. This is an area that needs further investigation as reducing barriers can help ensure that capital can flow to more STEM companies.

Company founder-investor education pairings, n=63



About the authors



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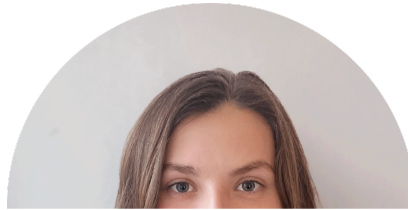
Daniel conducts data manipulation, visualisation and analysis as part of the Research & Consultancy team. He has a background in business analysis and commercial copywriting in Australia and the



FREYA HYDE

Freya performs data analysis and visualisation in the Research & Consultancy team, with a focus on design, and has worked on projects for Barclays, EY and JP Morgan. She holds a BA in History (International) from the University of Leeds, which included a year at Fudan University in Shanghai.

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